Dhanush has won four National Awards—two as an actor and two as producer. After films in Tamil, Hindi and English, he will soon be seen making his Telugu debut. Before all that, however, on July 22 we will see the actor play a key role in *The Gray Man*, a Netflix-produced action spectacle by Hollywood's leading directors, the Russo Brothers. It might perhaps not be a stretch to call the 38-year-old a bit of an overachiever. Dhanush, for his part, describes his two-decade long cinematic journey as "nothing short of a miracle". He says, "Never thought I would come this far. There are only two things I seek—success and to make my fans proud of me."

Dhanush, it is clear, has already got some of what he seeks. He may not have the same kind of zealous fan following and commercial success that his peers Vijay or Ajith do, or even some of the catchy sobriquets that so many South Indian actors acquire, but there are many who value his acting skills and ability to shuttle between mainstream entertainers (*3*, *Velaiilla Pattadhari aka VIP*, *Maari*) and hard-hitting dramas (*Karnan*, *Asuran*, *Vada Chennai*). Unlike many of his colleagues, he has also been able to cross linguistic boundaries and add a few Hindi films to his resumé, working with the likes of Aanand L. Rai and R. Balki. "I love to explore unknown territories," says Dhanush. "Choosing roles varies from industry to industry. What I look for is connectivity and the scope to deliver as a performer."

Dhanush's predilection for exploration had earlier taken him to Europe for the shoot of *The Extraordinary Journey of the Fakir* (2018), an adaptation of *The Extraordinary Journey of the Fakir Who Got Trapped in an Ikea Wardrobe*, a popular French novel. The film opened to middling reviews and didn't make a dent at the global box office, but having played the protagonist in his maiden international production won Dhanush some attention among international filmmakers. His recent collaborators happen to be "the biggest action filmmakers" in Joe and Anthony Russo, best known for directing two Captain America films and two Avengers blockbusters. In their latest film, *The Gray Man*, Dhanush plays Avik San, a brutal assassin albeit one with "a code of honour".

His preparation, he says, was more physical so as to be

***DHANUSH**, WHO PLAYS AN ASSASSIN IN* THE GRAY MAN, *SAYS THE RUSSO SIBLINGS HAVE GIVEN HIS CHARACTER "A BEAUTIFUL BACK STORY"*





BEYOND BORDERS Posters of *The Extraordinary Journey of The Fakir* (above) and *The Gray Man* (right)